Production Plan

From a squishy idea to a buildable game.



SECTION 1

MVP Definition

This plan scopes **Squnchies** down to the smallest version that proves the core promise: that squeezing a fidget toy to defend a calm little light feels good and holds up as a strategy game. The build sequence is ordered so that the riskiest, most important thing (the squeeze) is tested first, and every later phase adds something a player can react to.

THE MVP IN ONE LINE

The MVP is the **squeeze-to-defend core loop** + the **Squish economy** + **one full Room** (Bedroom Shelf), with **3 Squnchie types**, **3 Snarl types and one boss**, and a hand-tuned set of waves. Everything else layers on after the core is validated.

In the MVP

- **Squeeze mechanic.** Tap-hold to deform and charge, release to attack, perfect-squish timing window.
- **3 Squnchie types.** Squisher (single target), Splatter (area slow goo), Boinger (knockback).
- **3 Snarls + 1 boss.** Jitter, Knot, Spark, building to the Tangle boss.
- **1 Room.** Bedroom Shelf: one path, roughly 8 to 10 authored waves.
- **Economy.** Squish currency, 2 in-night upgrade tiers per toy, Calm meter to Hush Pulse.
- **Cozy shell.** Shelf home screen, cold-open tutorial, gentle-failure retry.

Cut from the MVP

DEFERRED TO LATER PHASES, IN BUILD ORDER:

- More Rooms: Toy Chest, Blanket Fort, Under the Bed, The Dream.
- Stretcher and Glommer toys; the armored Prickler Snarl.
- Texture and star meta-upgrades; Drops (collectible skins).
- Nightly Wind-Down daily; Fidget Mode endless.

THE V2 VISION (MATCHES THE GDD):

Co-op calm · Squnchie fusion · Shelf decoration · Squish puzzles · Adaptive / no-fail calm

WHY THIS IS THE RIGHT CUT

Cut everything that is content or meta-progression, and keep one complete vertical slice of the actual loop. One Room with the full economy and a boss is enough to answer the only question that matters early: is the squeeze fun, and does it carry a strategy layer? The rest is breadth you add once that yes is real.

SECTION 2

Build Sequence

PHASE	WHAT GETS BUILT	WHAT IS TESTABLE AFTER
1 **The squeeze**	One Squnchie, no enemies, no economy. Build the full tap, hold, deform, charge-ring, wobble and release, with synced haptics and sound and the perfect-squish timing window.	TESTABLE AFTER › Does squeezing **alone** feel good enough that people keep doing it with nothing at stake? This is the make-or-break feel test.
2 **One lane, one fight**	Add a single straight path, auto-spawning Jitters, one Squisher that auto-attacks and can also be squeezed, and a win / lose on the Hush Light.	TESTABLE AFTER › Is the loop (read the wave, squeeze at the right moment, clear it) legible and satisfying across one full wave?
3 **Economy, placement and content**	Add Squish currency, the place / upgrade UI, the full 3 toys and 3 Snarls plus Tangle, the Calm meter and Hush Pulse, and the complete Bedroom Shelf wave set.	TESTABLE AFTER › Can a player make real place-vs-upgrade-vs-save choices across a whole Room and reach a satisfying boss finish?
4 **Onboarding, tuning and cozy polish**	Add the 0 to 30 second cold-open tutorial, the Shelf home screen, difficulty tuning across the wave set, gentle-failure retry, and the art / audio / haptic pass.	TESTABLE AFTER › Can a new player learn it in 30 seconds and play an unguided 15-minute first session that lands the calm-from-chaos arc?

Sequenced around dependencies, not just priority. The economy cannot be tuned without the placement system, and wave difficulty cannot be tested without the full roster, so both wait for Phase 3. And none of it matters if the squeeze does not feel good, which is why Phase 1 builds that one thing in isolation before anything else is allowed to start.

SECTION 3

Technical Dependencies

- **The squeeze is the whole game.** Real-time, soft-body-style deformation with haptics, audio and a forgiving but readable perfect-squish window, at a steady frame rate on a phone. This is the single biggest feel and tech risk, and the reason Phase 1 stands alone.
- **Touch input model.** Press-and-hold charging that coexists with the auto-running board, stays multi-touch safe, and feels responsive on low-end devices.
- **Readable portrait HUD.** Path, Squish balance, Calm meter and each toy charge state all legible one-handed, at a glance, on a small screen.
- **Performance budget.** Many soft, glossy, animated creatures plus particle splats on a mid-range phone, without dropping frames or burning battery.
- **Data-driven tuning.** Waves and costs authored as data so they can be retuned fast once playtests start (depends on Phase 3 existing).

SECTION 4

Testing & Validation

FIRST-PLAYABLE: END OF PHASE 1

The player opens it to one glowing squishy toy on a dark, cozy shelf and a single prompt: press and hold. They squeeze. It deforms under their finger with haptics and a soft organic sound, a ring charges, they release, and it springs back with a satisfying pop. That is the entire first-playable: one toy, one feel, no menus.

Signals this is fun

- **Idle squeezing.** Players keep squeezing the toy when there is nothing to defend and no score. This is the strongest single signal the core feel works.
- **Voluntary replay.** In Phase 2 and later, players replay a night after winning, not to progress, just because the loop felt good.
- **Reaching for the perfect squish.** Players start timing the wobble on their own, without being told to.
- **Varied tower lines.** Different players favor different toys and placements, which means the strategy layer has room.
- **Lean in, then relax.** Players focus during a wave spike and visibly loosen up on the resolve beat.

What would make me change direction

- **No idle squeezing in Phase 1.** The core feel is not landing. First fix the squeeze itself: deformation amount, haptic strength, sound, and the wobble timing, before adding any systems. If feel cannot carry it, better to know in week one.
- **The squeeze feels like a chore** on top of the auto-board in Phase 2. Rebalance how much the manual squeeze matters versus the calm auto-layer, dialing toward "calm with moments of lean-in" rather than constant input.
- **Players feel tested, not soothed.** Soften failure and pacing before adding any challenge content. The game's job is to lower shoulders, and that goal wins over difficulty.

CONSISTENCY CHECK

The cut list above and the GDD's If I Had More Time section tell the same story: the squeeze plus one Room is the validated core, and co-op, fusion, Shelf decoration, Squish puzzles and adaptive calm are the second-version vision that grows out of it.